Byteforms

Core Rules

The World of Byteforms

Beyond the screen lies the Wireframe, a vast digital realm that grows and changes on its own. At its core stands Synthcity, a safe hub where explorers gather. But outside its walls stretch the Wilds, shifting landscapes where strange beings of living code roam: the Byteforms.

As a Compiler, you are one of those who learned to harness this world. You don't just encounter Byteforms, you reprogram them, fuse them, and command them in battle. Some Compilers seek knowledge, others chase power, but all are drawn deeper into the Wilds as the Wireframe continues to expand.

Key Terms

Programs - A Program is any card in play.

Boot/Booted - A face up program is considered booted. Turning a Program face up, is called booting it.

Suspend/Suspended - A face down Program is called suspended. Turning a Program face down, is called suspending a Program. While a program is suspended, it is treated as a blank card and has no abilities, unless stated otherwise.

Attack and Durability - How much damage a Program deals when it attacks and how much damage it can recieve before being terminated.

Adjacent and Neighboring - Adjacent spaces are directly next to a Program (up, down, left, or right). Neighboring spaces include adjacent and diagonal spaces (any of the eight surrounding).

Core Types

Every Byteform is built from a core type, its source of power and identity within the Wireframe. There are six core types: Firewire, Rootlink, Psycore, Android, Blackhat, and Torrent. Each type comes with its own style of play: some thrive on aggression, others on trickery, swarming, or control.

Firewire

Psycore

Rootlink

Android

Blackhat

Torrent

Card Types

In Byteforms there are four main card types,

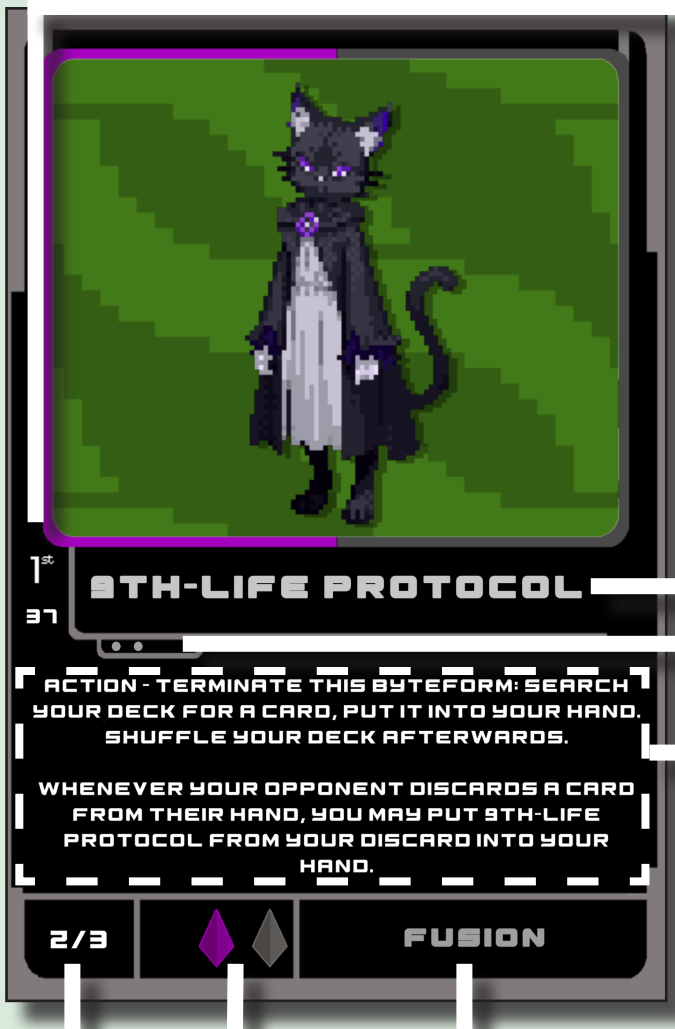
Byteforms - The coded creatures you boot on to the grid to fight for you. Byteforms come in multiple different subtypes, Basics, Fusions, Evolutions, and Specials.

Nodes - Structures that provide passive effects or actions to support your strategy.

Peripherals - Low-power utilities that give you small but useful advantages.

Commands - High-impact plays that can shift the flow of battle.

Parts of a Card



Set Symbol and number

Card Name

Ability Text

Rarity

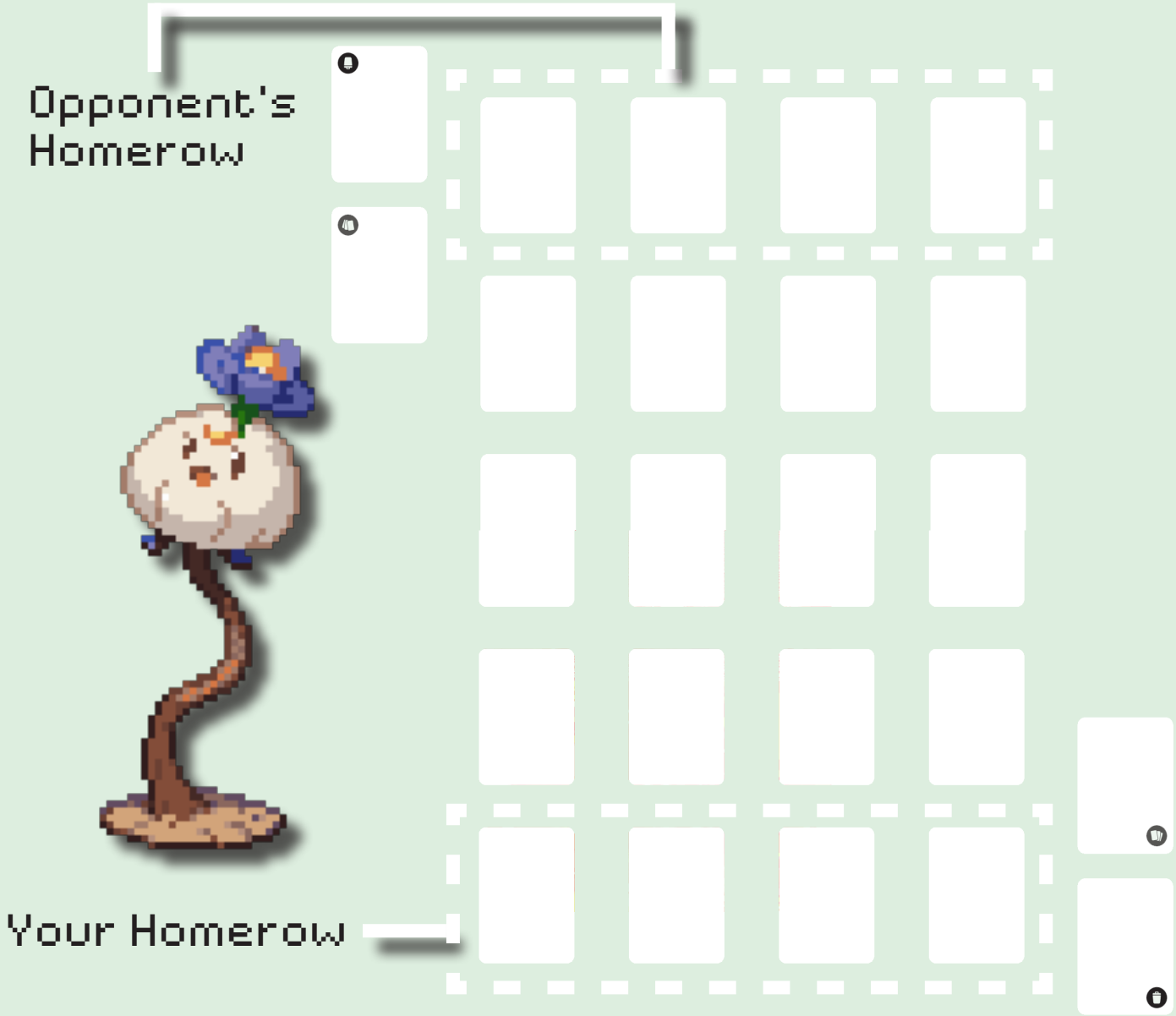
Card Type

Cores

Attack / Durability

Zones of the Game

Byteforms takes place on a 4 x 5 grid, with the closest row being your home row, and the furthest being your opponent's home row. You have a space for your deck and a space for your discard pile as well.



Playing the Game

Winning the game -

To win a game of Byteforms you must score 10 points by removing your opponents programs from the board.

Setting up to play -

1.) Determine which player will be going first at random.

2.) Both players shuffle their deck and draw a hand of 7 cards. Players may then decide to mulligan by shuffling their hand into their deck and drawing 7 new cards. Then for each time you've mulliganned before, shuffle 1 card back into your deck. (On your first mulligan, shuffle 0 Back in. On your second, shuffle 1 back. Etc.)

3.) Starting with the first player, each player plays as many Basic Byteforms from their hand in to their homerow suspended.

Turn Phases

Each turn goes through 4 phases in the following order.

Boot Phase -

Boot any number of suspended programs you control. Then all booted programs you control regain their cores.

Draw Phase -

Draw 1 card from the top of your deck.

Main Phase -

Take any actions listed on the next pages in any order and as many times as you'd like.

Suspend Phase -

Any effects that refer to the suspend phase trigger now. If you don't control any programs, you lose the game. Discard cards from your hand if you are above the maximum hand size (7 cards). After this phase ends, the turn passes to the next player.

Actions

Play a Peripheral - Play a Peripheral card from your hand, resolve its effect, then discard it.

Play a Command - Play a Command card from your hand, resolve it's effect, then discard it. You may only play one command card per turn. The player who goes first may not play a command on their first turn.

Play a Node - You may play a node into your homerow or adjacent to a program you control booted.

Play a Basic Byteform - Reveal a Basic Byteform from your hand, and it put it into an empty zone on your homerow suspended.

Play an Evolution Byteform - Reveal an Evolution Byteform from your hand, discard the Byteform it the evolves from that you control, and place the evolution into the zone the previous Byteform occupied suspended.

Play a Fusion Byteform - To play a fusion, you must first play a card or use an ability that tells you to fuse two or more byteforms you control. Discard the Byteforms you are fusing and place the fusion, from your hand, into play on one of the zones they inhabited. The Fusion must have the matching cores to be fused into. (You may fuse a Rootlink Byteform and a Firewire Byteform into a Firewire Rootlink Fusion Byteform.)

Move - A Byteform moves 1 space into an adjacent, unoccupied zone. Costs that Byteform 1 Core. The first move action a Byteform takes each boot doesn't cost them a core.

Printed Action - If a program has an ability with "Action -" on it, you may do that ability as an action. If it is on a Byteform, it costs that Byteform 1 core to resolve that ability.

Attack - A Byteform may attack an adjacent program you don't control. Each program deals it's attack to the other program(s). If you attack a suspended program, reveal it to calculate damage, then if it is not terminated, boot it. Costs that Byteform 1 core.

Cores and Actions

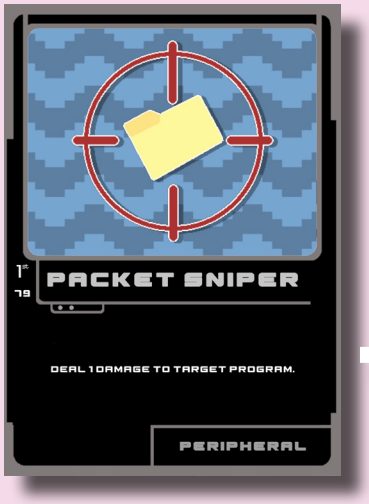
When you take an action with a Byteform (Move, Attack, Printed Action) it will cost them a core to do so. When a Byteform has no cores remaining, they become Suspended immediately after the effect that causes them lose all of their cores resolves.

Ashnet could take a single attack action and then would become suspended, since it only has one core. While Gearshade could take an attack action and it's printed action and then would become suspended, since it has 2 cores.

Scoring Points

A game of Byteforms is won when a player gains 10 points.

Whenever you terminate an opponent's program, you gain points equal to the printed number of cores on that program. If the program has no printed cores, gain 1 point. Then the player who controlled that program draws cards from their deck equal to the number of printed cores. Neutral effects (like
Overheat) do not cause players to gain points or draw cards.



If you played a packet sniper to deal 1 damage to your opponent's Nano Croak you would gain 1 point, and your opponent would draw 1 card, because Nano Croak has 1 core.

Building your Deck

When building your deck, you construct a deck and you may construct a sideboard. Your deck must contain at least 60 cards, and your sideboard may contain up to 15 cards. You may only include up to 4 cards with the same name across your deck and sideboard.

Keywords and Conditions

Overheat - a condition that is applied to programs. When a program with overheat is suspended, it takes damage equal to the overheat condition, and then loses all Overheat.

Packet Loss - a condition that is applied to players. Your maximum hand is reduced by the ammount of Packet Loss you have. After you discard down, reduce your Packet Loss by 1.

Trojan - a condition that is applied to players. If you have 10 Trojan counters, you lose the game.

Corruption - If this program is attacked while suspended, the attacker is terminated after.

Edgewalk - This program treats the left and right sides of the grid as adjacent.

Datalock X - If you target a program with Datalock with any non-attack ability, you must discard X cards first.

Quarantine - When a Program with Quarantine would boot, remove Quarantine from it instead.